

THEMATIC ANALYSIS: SACRIFICE, PUBLIC IMAGE, & PERSONAL HONOR

Literary Study Packet — Analyzing the Friction Between External Reputation and Inner Identity

Student Name: _____

Date: _____

Class Period: _____

Text Analyzed: _____

1. Conceptual Framework & Key Definitions

Thematic Pillar	Literary Definition	Central Analytic Question
Public Image	The collective label, stereotype, or reputation thrust upon an individual by society or a rival social class.	How does society's label limit or misrepresent who this character actually is?
Personal Honor & Identity	An individual's internal moral code, core values, authentic character, and sense of personal integrity.	What values does the character cling to when no one else is watching?
Sacrifice	The conscious surrender of safety, social standing, reputation, or life for a higher moral purpose or loved one.	What is the character willing to give up to preserve their integrity or protect others?

2. Character Matrix: Public Perception vs. Private Integrity

Character	Public Image & External Stereotype	Private Identity & True Honor	Sacrifice Made & Its Meaning
Johnny Cade	A quiet, traumatized 'hood'; viewed as weak or a juvenile delinquent by society.	Deeply reflective, brave, empathetic, and possessor of an innate desire to protect innocent life.	Sacrifices his physical life in the burning church to save children, proving true heroism.
Dallas Winston	Hardened, dangerous criminal; proud of his police record and street toughness.	Fiercely protective of Johnny; uses cold armor to shield himself from grief and vulnerability.	Sacrifices his safety to guide Johnny & Ponyboy, but loses his will to live when Johnny dies.
Darrel Curtis	A tough, cold greaser who works roof jobs and acts overly strict toward his brothers.	A devoted older brother driven by intense love, fear of losing his family, and high integrity.	Sacrifices a college football scholarship and social mobility to raise his younger brothers.
Ponyboy Curtis	Greaser labeled as a hoodlum and potential troublemaker by authority figures.	Sensitive artist and scholar who appreciates poetry, sunsets, and human connection.	Sacrifices his long hair and comfort to stay loyal to Johnny and re-evaluate his worldview.

3. Deep Analysis & Written Reflection Prompts

Prompt A (Public Image vs. Internal Worth): How do social expectations and public stereotypes force characters to put on a front or 'armor'? Cite one example where a character's public image conflicts with their true self.

Prompt B (The Price of Personal Honor): In what ways can choosing personal honor over public approval lead to tragic or heroic consequences? Compare Johnny's choice to Dally's final reaction.

Prompt C (Modern Connection): Does society still demand that young people sacrifice their authentic identity to maintain a public image? Explain how this dynamic appears in today's world.
